

REP. SUMMER LEE, SEN. MARKEY REINTRODUCE LEGISLATION TO MANDATE CIVIL RIGHTS OFFICES IN FEDERAL AGENCIES THAT MANAGE ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

January 15, 2026

[PRESS RELEASE](#)

[Bill Text \(PDF\)](#)

WASHINGTON, D.C. – JANUARY 15, 2026 —

Today, **Congresswoman Summer L. Lee (PA-12)** and **Senator Edward J. Markey (D-MA)** reintroduced the *Eliminating Bias in Algorithmic Systems (BIAS) Act*, legislation to ensure that every federal agency that uses, funds, or oversees artificial intelligence (AI) has a dedicated Office of Civil Rights focused on combating AI-driven bias, discrimination, and related harms.

The bill would require federal agencies to establish or strengthen civil rights offices with staff trained in algorithmic accountability and civil rights enforcement, and to regularly report to Congress on how AI systems are impacting vulnerable communities. These reports would also include recommendations for legislative action to address emerging harms.

“I represent Pittsburgh and Western Pennsylvania, a region that reflects both our industrial past and the technologies shaping our future. As a growing hub for innovation in Artificial Intelligence, we have a responsibility to make sure AI does not deepen the inequities Black, brown, low-income, and other vulnerable communities already face. AI carries the same biases humans do, and without oversight, those harms will be replicated if not amplified,” said Rep. Lee. **“The Eliminating BIAS Act puts real guardrails in place to demand transparency, accountability, and strong civil rights protections, especially in an age of rampant disinformation and misinformation. I’m proud to partner with Senator Markey to ensure innovation never comes at the cost of our civil rights or human dignity.”**

“From housing to health care to public services, AI is increasingly being used to make consequential decisions, diagnoses, recommendations, and predictions that can significantly alter our lives,” said Senator Markey. **“As the risks of bias and discrimination in AI systems become more apparent, the federal government must lead by example and protect marginalized communities that face the greatest consequences when AI goes wrong. My Eliminating BIAS Act will ensure that the government has the proper tools, resources, and personnel to protect these communities and mitigate AI’s dangerous effects, while providing Congress with critical information to address algorithmic harms.”**

Algorithms are already discriminating against disadvantaged communities in a variety of contexts. For example, companies have used algorithms to **exclude** users of certain gender identities from viewing job advertisements, **block** advertisements for clothing made for people with disabilities, and **charge** higher interest rates for minorities. In addition, facial recognition technologies have the highest error rates among **Black women**. If left unchecked, biased algorithms will further exacerbate discrimination, inequality, and racism.

“Algorithmic systems affect nearly every part of daily life, making decisions about employment, housing, education, health, finance, and so much more. These systems have been shown to repeatedly create biased outcomes that disproportionately harm Black people and other communities of color. Yet, this administration has encouraged rapid adoption of algorithms without regard for civil rights. The *Eliminating Bias in Algorithmic Systems Act* presents an alternative path where agencies are required to report the harms created by algorithmic systems and ways to mitigate them” said Jina John, Policy Counsel at the Lawyers’ Committee for Civil Rights Under Law.

“Common Sense Media applauds Senator Markey for reintroducing the Eliminating BIAS Act,” said Amina Fazlullah, Head of Tech Policy Advocacy at Common Sense Media. **“Without intentional choices to prioritize fairness, AI systems will not learn from past mistakes and will continue to replicate historic inequities, putting children, families, and marginalized communities at risk. This bill ensures federal agencies have the expertise, transparency, and oversight needed to identify and address discriminatory algorithms. As AI increasingly influences access to education, healthcare, employment, and housing, strong safeguards are essential to build public trust in how the government uses these technologies.”**

“New America’s Open Technology Institute is pleased to endorse Senator Markey’s and Congresswoman Lee’s Eliminating BIAS Act, which requires federal agencies to establish civil rights offices focused on bias, discrimination, and other harms that may arise from the use of algorithms. This proposed legislation centers rights and fairness in the federal government’s development, use, and oversight of artificial intelligence tools. Empowering civil rights offices within federal agencies is critical to ensuring that our government uses artificial intelligence in ways that safeguard vulnerable communities and the health of our democracy.” said Prem Trivedi, Director, New America’s Open Technology Institute.

“The National Urban League proudly supports the Eliminating BIAS Act—legislation that is long overdue. While AI holds great promise, far too often opaque algorithms reinforce systemic inequities that disproportionately harm Black, Brown, Indigenous, and immigrant communities. By requiring federal agencies to stand up civil rights offices staffed with technologists, mandating transparency to Congress, and establishing a cross agency working group, this bill puts accountability and equity at the heart of the government’s use of AI. Today, our government must lead by example—ensuring that technology uplifts every community,” said Marc H. Morial, President and CEO of the National Urban League.

The *Eliminating BIAS Act* is cosponsored in the Senate by Senators Jeff Merkley (D-Ore.), Elizabeth Warren (D-Mass.), Peter Welch (D-Vt.), Adam Schiff (D-Cal.), Ron Wyden (D-Ore.) and Cory Booker (D-N.J.) and in the House of Representatives by Reps. Eleanor Holmes Norton (D-DC), Rashida Tlaib (MI-12), Delia C. Ramirez (IL-03), Henry C. “Hank” Johnson Jr. (GA-04), Shri Thanedar (MI-13), Bennie G. Thompson (MS-02), Dwight Evans (PA-03), Suzanne Bonamici (OR-01), Bonnie Watson Coleman (NJ-12), Valerie P. Foushee (NC-04), Al Green (TX-09).

The Eliminating BIAS Act is endorsed by the Lawyers’ Committee for Civil Rights Under Law, the Leadership Conference on Civil and Human Rights, Common Sense Media, National Urban League, Center for Democracy and Technology, Electronic Privacy Information Center, Free Press Action, Open Technology Institute, Asian Americans Advancing Justice, The Trevor Project, and Access Now.

Congresswoman Summer Lee serves on the House Committee on Oversight and Government Reform and the Committee on Education and Workforce. Since taking office in January 2023, she **has delivered historic levels of federal investment totaling over \$2.4 Billion** brought back to Western PA, including over \$580 million for infrastructure, over \$110 million for affordable transit, over \$500 million to keep clean energy manufacturing at home in Pennsylvania, and over \$55 million on clean energy efforts in and around schools to help keep our kids and communities safe. These investments will help improve Western Pennsylvania’s infrastructure and transit, ensure cleaner air and drinking water, lower housing costs, fund research institutions, fuel clean manufacturing, fund STEM innovation and entrepreneurship, boost workforce development, and create thousands of good paying union jobs. Lee and her team have also delivered casework and constituent services to over 3,000 constituents with issues ranging from helping our seniors and disabled community access Medicare and social security to helping folks secure housing and helping families with immigration support and passports.

NEWSROOM

[Newsletter Subscribe](#)

[Press Kit](#)

[Press Releases](#)



VISITS ARE BY APPOINTMENT—PLEASE CALL 412-214-5000 TO SCHEDULE

Washington DC Office ★

2437 Rayburn House Office Building
Washington, DC 20515
Phone: (202) 225-2135

Clairton Satellite Office

551 Ravensburg Blvd
Clairton, PA 15025

Monroeville Satellite Office

2700 Monroeville Blvd
Monroeville, PA 15146

Bethel Park District Office

5100 W Library Ave
Bethel Park, PA 15102
Phone: (412) 214-5000

Beechview Satellite Office

1555 Broadway Avenue
2nd Floor
Pittsburgh, PA 15216
Phone: (412) 214-5000

Pittsburgh District Office ★

211 N Whitfield St.
Suite 802
Pittsburgh, PA 15206
Phone: (412) 214-5000
Fax: (771) 200-5826

Jeannette District Office

110 S 2nd Street
Jeannette, PA 15644
Phone: (412) 214-5000

